

a new avatar just makes work more meaningful and challenging. India has so many beautiful forms of traditional textiles, which can be styled and given an international edge," says Shyamal Shodhan, one half of the Ahmedabad-based label Shyamal & Bhumika. The duo has collectively worked towards reviving the ancient *Ashavali* sari of Ahmedabad besides working with traditional handwoven textiles like silk *ikats*, handwoven brocade silks from Varanasi and many varieties of handwoven fabrics from Bihar. "Initially, it was tough to get the weavers to weave the gorgeous age-old *Ashavali* designs and use the same heavy quality *zari* threads, which were used a century ago. The Amdavadi *Ashavali* sari grew extinct not only due to commercialisation, but also because it was not thin enough to drape closer to the body," he says. Shyamal & Bhumika softened the fabric so that it would drape better and now use it generously in their Indian wear and bridal wear collections.

Here are couturiers who are fashioning clothes where the fabric becomes the true hero. It is the reapplication of traditional crafts for contemporary designs that these designers are truly interested in. Like vintage wine in a new, sleeker, global-friendly bottle. But they are quick to caution—displaying traditional techniques doesn't only mean heavily embroidered *ghaghra cholis*, endless reams of *zardozi* covered saris and Swarovski encrusted *razz-matazz*. "I focus on traditional arts and craft and present it as an accent or detail. My silhouettes are necessarily Western and the flavour is Indian. Since we target both local and international clients, it is important

◀ Sirali (Gunjan and Rahul)



They have developed a unique non-woven fabric where threads are fused together to create designs.

"We believe rich material can also make a priceless fabric."

Conscious Culture

Designers with a conscience have taken to ethical dressing with a vengeance. Design doyenne Ritu Kumar's hip range of jeans come dyed in vegetable colours. Bangalore designer Deepika Govind's latest fall-winter collection boasted a line in Assamese muga silk, which has natural uv rays protection properties. Govind has in the past created fabrics using bamboo fibre and other eco-friendly variations in silk. While veterans have used vegetable dyes in their designs, now the newer set seems to be eager to continue the tradition. Aneeth Arora's debut collection at LFW reflected her use of natural dye specialists from Jaipur. Bangalore-based brand Ravage by Raj Shroff and Neetu Gupta (below) also displays a sound sense of organic fabrics despite their modern approach to design. Style with soul, indeed.



Samant Chauhan ▶



This Bihar-born has reinvented Bhagalpuri silk with different techniques and digital prints.

"I prefer to develop fabric from the yarn stage to change its property."

that we give international buyers something Indian in the cuts they are accustomed to," says Ahmedabad-based designer Deepti Toor. Her autumn-winter line at the LFW showcased a unique fabric—papier mache-made water repellent with jute and natural dyed with onions and tomatoes. Created in collaboration with textile artist Ilimadri Ghosh of Platypus Design, interestingly enough, the variations in the waistlines and yokes in her garments were woven into the fabric beforehand. "Each design was uniquely crafted. The idea is to create textiles along with design," says Toor, who believes the trademark of her clothes lies in the concept and execution, rather than a bling overload.

Speaking a language of understated execution is Samant Chauhan, 27, who has given a new lease of life to Bhagalpuri raw silk by texturing and interlacing it and giving it a modern twist with digital prints. "I prefer to develop fabric from the yarn stage in order to manipulate its property. I work with an NGO called Pradhan where we are actively creating employment for weavers in Bhagalpur," says the Bihar-born Samant, who made an impressive debut in the Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week's Hi5 category in March and is currently working on combining Bhagalpuri silk with lycra and developing bamboo yarn.

Another LFW find, Aneeth Arora's debut line used woven fabrics from different parts of India. The weavers from Roje Eshanshali, Salahkati, Assam, weavers from

